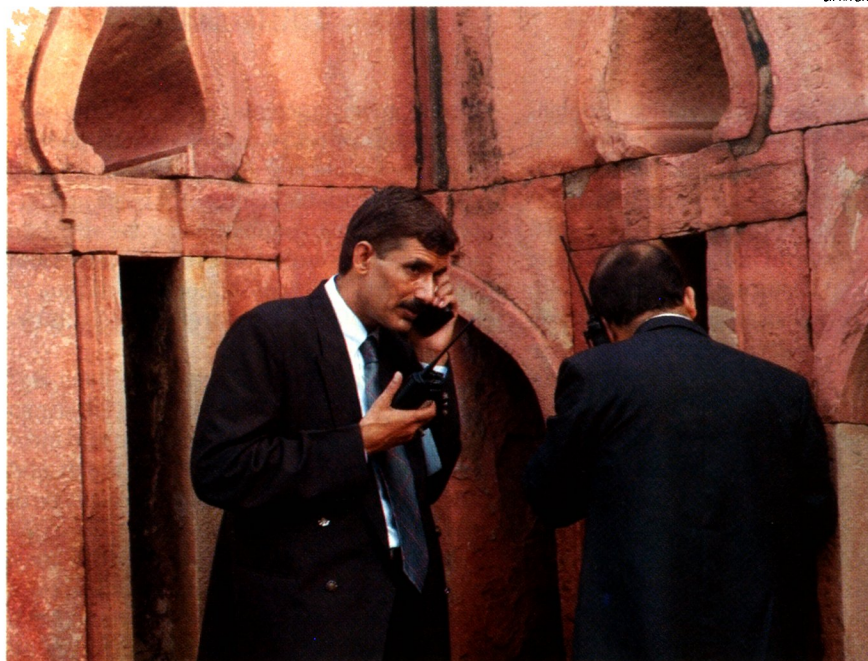




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Enemy within: The ineptitude of the political executive has prevented any action on terrorism

State of Inaction

THE CENTRE IS NOT ALONE IN ITS FAILURES. DESPITE LIBERAL CENTRAL SCHEMES UNDERWRITING SECURITY RELATED EXPENDITURE AND POLICE MODERNISATION IN THE STATES, THE LATTER HAVE FAILED EVEN TO SPEND THE AMOUNTS ALLOCATED.

they have established is not negligible. On objective parameters of its performance in countering terrorism, however, the NSG would have to be declared a failure, not through any defalcation on the part of its officers and personnel, but through error of design.

"In the 20th century, the state was the chief enemy of freedom," philosopher John Gray notes, "today, it is the weakness of the state that most threatens freedom." It is the infirmities of the presently under-manned, under-trained, under-equipped and primitive security and justice systems, and not lack of some inchoate 'great idea' or 'out-of-the-box solution', that lie at the core of our inability to effectively tackle extremist subversion, terrorism and sub-conventional warfare in India. Manpower deficits, for instance, are endemic. India has 126 policemen per 1 lakh population, compared to western ratios that range between 250 and 500 per 1 lakh. Worse, the Indian ratio is worked out against sanctioned posts, and there is a 9.75 per cent deficit against sanctions across the country, with some states recording a nearly 40 per cent deficit. Across the country, there is a 17 per cent deficit in the sanctioned strength of Indian Police Service cadres. Western intelligence and enforcement agencies are backed with cutting-edge technologies, the best technical support, enormous resources and responsive and efficient judicial and legislative systems. The Indian security apparatus,

meanwhile, remains trapped in policing techniques and technologies, most of which date back to the early 20th century. Even the best of them are decades old. Other elements of the justice system, including legislation and a formalistic, lingering, unaccountable and often hostile judiciary, offer little support to law and order administration or counter-terrorism in India.

The intelligence apparatus is even more ill-equipped for the challenge. Despite its image of omnipresence, the total strength of field personnel engaged in intelligence gathering in the Intelligence Bureau (IB) is under 3,500 for this country of 1.2 billion people. The Centre offers no explanation for its inability to implement long-standing decisions—based on the Girish Saxena Committee recommendations—dating back to 2001, for a system-wide reform and massive

upgrading of intelligence capabilities. Crucially, the Multi-Agency Centre, the national intelligence database, and the Joint Task Force on Intelligence, which were to be set up under the IB, remain mere shell organisations, more than seven years after the decision was taken to create these, with endemic manpower, technological and resource shortages. The Saxena Committee recommendation to immediately increase the IB's strength by 3,000 personnel, accepted by the government in February 2001, has resulted in the sanction of just 1,400 additional posts till September 2008. The Centre is, of course, not alone in its failures. Despite liberal Central schemes underwriting security related expenditure and police modernisation in the states, the latter have failed even to spend the monies allocated (utilisation in 2006-07, for instance, stood at 63.71 per cent).

The gravest threat to India's security is not Pakistan, not the ISI, not terrorism, but the limitless acts of omission, the venality and the ineptitude of the political and administrative executive, and the complete absence of accountability in the top echelons of Government. Our greatest enemy is not only within. It has captured the highest nodes of power and decision-making in the country.

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